

Numbers, not ideology, determine politics in India. That truth was brought home yet again when Janata Dal-United (JD-U) leader Nitish Kumar dumped the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and the Congress—for the second time in seven years—and went back to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which he had just abandoned in August 2022, taking oath as Bihar's chief minister for the ninth time on January 28. However, Nitish's latest about-turn hurts more than just the *mahagathbandhan* in the state, it has ended all hope of any credible opposition against the BJP in the Lok Sabha election coming up just after spring. "By taking one of the key architects of I.N.D.I.A., the BJP has dealt a psychological blow to the Opposition," says election strategist-turned-political activist Prashant Kishor.

It will not be for want of trying on Nitish's part, though. He was a key architect of the grand grouping that was the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, even if the effort to arrive at the acronym I.N.D.I.A. was rather contrived. It was at his official Circular Road residence in Patna last June that the bloc of 27 parties had amalgamated with a singular objective—to dethrone the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led BJP from the Centre. The strategy was simple—to consolidate anti-BJP votes by fielding common candidates in as many seats as possible. Nitish even convinced allies who were reluctant to cede space to the Congress that I.N.D.I.A. would be electorally ineffective without the only party that had a presence across the country. He handed them a new narrative too, by making good on his promise of a caste survey in his own state and strengthening the demand for a similar exercise across the nation.

In its full strength, with effective seat-sharing agreements among partners, I.N.D.I.A. could have dented the BJP's chances in at least 313 out of the 543 Lok Sabha seats in 10 states (see graphic *Dwindling Imprint*), where the saffron party had won 150 seats, or nearly half its total tally of 303 in 2019. In Bihar itself, the combined strength of the JD(U), RJD, Congress and Communist Party of India-Marxist Leninist (CPI-ML) would have shot up to 52 per cent, going by the extrapolated results of the 2020 assembly election. When Nitish deserted the BJP in August 2022, the number of Lok Sabha seats in Bihar where the saffron side was vulnerable had jumped from four to 10.

Now, the I.N.D.I.A. story is slowly unravelling. Nitish has jumped ship, and West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee—whose Trinamool Congress is another key I.N.D.I.A. constituent—announced her decision to go solo in the state on January 24. The two states together account for 82 seats and were among the handful of states where the Opposition alliance was hoping to bring down the BJP's existing tally. Nitish's return is expected to improve the BJP's chances in Bihar. According to political analysts, the JD(U) still commands